tive subconscious of the country...it is its heart," says Prabhat Choudhary, founder of communication agency Spice. "What happens in Varanasi resonates throughout the country." A veteran entertainment marketing strategist, Choudhary began suggesting the city as a pit stop for promotional campaigns over 12 years ago. But not everyone saw the possibilities he did. "We faced a lot of resistance initially. To the film distribution teams, it didn't make sense, as Varanasi is not a huge revenue centre," he says. Currently, it has four multiplexes and two single screens, but the city doesn't even rank in the top 15 in revenue generators.

Nonetheless, Choudhary persisted and *3 Idiots* became one of the first films to include Varanasi in its promotional itinerary. Indeed, hero Aamir Khan even took a rickshaw and travelled through the narrow lanes of the old city to search for his mother Zeenat's birthplace in the Teliyanala area near Prahlad Ghat. Of course, he had his face covered with a muffler and was wearing a pair of old sunglasses to avoid being recognised.

But Choudhary has done a lot more to get Varanasi on the movie map. This includes making Shah Rukh Khan eat a Banarasi *paan* for *Don 2* (2011); getting Tiger Shroff to do Ganga *pranaam* with fitness enthusiasts at 5 am on Tulsi Ghat for his debut, *Heropanti* (2014); taking team *Commando 2* (2017), including producer Vipul Shah, director Deven Bhojwani and lead cast, Vidyut Jammwal and Adah Sharma, to seek the blessings of Lord Hanuman at the Sankat Mochan Hanuman Temple; and convincing Rajamouli that if he wanted *Bahubali* (2015) to "belong to the entire nation", he needed to establish a connection with Varanasi.

For Vipul Shah, going to Varanasi for promotions makes business sense. "I feel that Varanasi has to be in the plans of any film that is releasing in 2,500-plus screens, wants to go into India's interiors, and reach out to the mass audience," he says. "It's huge in terms of impact and awareness. When we visit, word about the film spreads not just in Uttar Pradesh but also to West Bengal and Bihar."

Of course, Varanasi has always been on Bollywood's radar as a shooting location. From Satyajit Ray in *Aparajito* to more recently Aanand L. Rai in *Raanjhanaa* and Neeraj Ghaywan in *Masaan*, many have featured the city as an integral part in their narrative.

Shooting in UP has become easier with the state government's Film Bandhu programme, which has eased the permissions process. Producers are also lured with subsidies if they employ local artistes and shoot a significant chunk of the project in the state. So far (till March 2022), 40 film projects had

BANARAS IN FILM



WATER *(2007)*
Deepa Mehta's film centres on the fraught lives of widows at an ashram. Lisa Ray plays one forced into prostitution while Seema Biswas rebels against the oppressive system



LAGA CHUNARI MEIN DAAG *(2007)*
Rani Mukerji is the big sister who becomes an escort in Mumbai to help her family back in Varanasi

MASAAN *(2015)*
Vicky Kaushal and Richa Chadha are grieving souls trying to stay afloat in director Neeraj Ghaywan and writer Varun Grover's affecting drama





MUKTI BHAWAN *(2017)*
A father's last wish is to breathe his last in the holy city. A son reluctantly checks him into a hotel where the two now wait for the end

THE LAST COLOR *(2019)*
Chef Vikas Khanna's directorial debut, adapted from his novel, is about a street child who befriends a widow (Neena Gupta) and a transwoman

